



TEMPLE TURMOIL: Traditionalists want the churidar ban reintroduced

consensus was arrived at a recent conference organised by GDB. "We have agreed to allow anyone in who has faith in Hindu gods, temples and rituals," Rajasekharan had said.

The decision to allow churidar-clad women and non-Hindus into the temple is being looked upon by Hindu

groups as the Marxist-led Government trying to "force change down Hindu throats". "Why should secularists and Communists meddle in the affairs of the Hindu faith? Why should the Government appoint a board to administer and control temples, and their wealth? Why don't they dare do such things when it comes to Christian or Muslim religious affairs?", asks P. K. Krishnadas, state BJP president. Rajasekharan says the corruption and outdated practices in the Devaswom boards have grown phenomenally, with every ruling party having their own representatives in them.

The recent *prasna* has now thrown a spanner into GDB's work—indirectly backed by the LDF Government—to alter some of the traditional practices at the temple "to suit the changing times". Justice K. Sreedevi, chairperson of the Kerala Women's Commission has called it an attempt to reimpose outdated traditions and the diktat of the priests. Famous writer Sukumar Azheekode finds it ironical that a dress code is sought to be imposed in the name of a liberal and fun-loving god who would mischievously walk away

with the clothes of bathing gopikas.

The LDF Government says it has a duty to make its position clear on issues related to the bans—which are based on religion and gender, and are unconstitutional even when they are practised in places of worship. The Government has also resolved to support the revocation of the traditional ban on the entry of women (of menstrual age) into Sabarimala Ayyappa Temple. "It is wrong to say that governments cannot interfere in religious customs. If it wasn't for the government's intervention, heinous practices like the barring of backward castes from temples and human and animal sacrifices would have continued in the name of tradition, faith and god," says Sudhakaran.

Rajasekharan claims it was reform movements inside the religion that led to the end of such antiquated practices. "Governments were made to bring about legislation, spurred by internal movements. Let's wait for that to happen, instead of jumping in to force changes that make them unsustainable." Clearly, this temple's turmoils are far from over. ■

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